

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE COOK ISLANDS

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The Cook Islands are a small, self-governing Pacific nation of fifteen islands scattered across a great ocean of nearly two million square kilometres — a Westminster democracy in free association with New Zealand, ocean-dependent in economy and culture, tourism-reliant, and climate-vulnerable as a nation of reefs and low atolls. And they sit at the very frontier of extraction, deciding in the open a question few nations have faced: whether to mine the deep ocean floor. The seabed of its waters is carpeted with **polymetallic nodules** — among the world's greatest deposits of the cobalt, nickel, and manganese the world increasingly wants for its batteries and its clean-energy transition — and the nation has granted licences to explore them, even as it holds the whole of that ocean as **Marae Moana**, the largest marine park on Earth, and even as the deep-sea ecosystem the mining would touch remains so little understood that its harm cannot yet be measured or reliably predicted. There is no landmark victory yet to point to — because this is a moment to shape, not a harm to reverse. And, crucially, it is being decided within a genuine, open democracy, where the levers of community, law, tradition, and science truly work.

A community in the Cook Islands, at a decision still open, works with genuinely strong tools, in a working democracy. The distinctive one is the **precautionary principle**: a deep-sea mining still at exploration, over an ecosystem so little understood its harm cannot be measured, can be held to the precaution the government itself professes — where harm is uncertain and potentially irreversible, the burden is to prove safety, not to assume it. The **Marae Moana marine park** — the world's largest — and its **Council, technical advisory group, and marine spatial plan** are the ocean's own governance, whose purpose can be strengthened and held against the mining. The **Seabed Minerals Authority's own precautionary commitments** can be held to. The **tuna fishery and the ocean economy** are a powerful, evidence-based stake at real risk. **Parliament, the courts, the free press, and civil society** carry genuine voice, scrutiny, and legal avenues; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And **traditional authority and the world's science** ground it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The mining is still at exploration, years from any commercial decision — so this is a moment to shape, not a harm to reverse. The government advocates the mining as development and a contribution to the clean-energy transition, an argument made in good faith that must be met fairly, not dismissed. The science is genuinely uncertain and cuts both ways. The marine park, though vast, is mixed-use, and its protections can be bypassed for mining. The economy is small and seeks the revenue. And there is no landmark victory yet to point to. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the precautionary principle applied, the marine park's purpose strengthened, a barely-known deep sea protected until it is understood, the decision shaped in the open — in a working democracy where the odds, at a decision still open, are real.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here not by reversing a harm but by shaping a decision still open, in a democracy that genuinely responds. Hold the deep-sea mining to the precautionary principle the government itself professes; strengthen the Marae Moana marine park's purpose; ground the case in the tuna, the ocean economy, and the world's science; use Parliament, the courts, and the press; and carry the traditional authority and the community with you — meeting fairly the government's good-faith case for development and clean-energy

minerals.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

The Cook Islands are unusual and hopeful: a working democracy deciding a frontier question in the open, before any harm is done. That is the first honest truth — this is a moment to shape, not a harm to reverse. And the government's case for the mining is made in good faith and must be met fairly; the science is genuinely uncertain; the marine park is mixed-use; and the small economy seeks the revenue. So aim at the winnable — the precautionary principle applied, the park strengthened, the deep sea protected until it is understood — through the genuine channels of a democracy, and by winning the argument rather than dismissing the other side.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Cook Islands seabed decision runs through a democratic, traditional, and marine-governed system. The **government and the Seabed Minerals Authority** grant the licences and will decide on any harvesting, and are answerable, in a democracy, to their people and their own precautionary commitments. The **Marae Moana Council, its technical advisory group, and the marine spatial plan** are the ocean's own governance — a real lever, with traditional leaders and civil society at the table. And **Parliament, the courts, the free press, and civil society** hold genuine voice, scrutiny, and legal avenues. Map who decides at each stage, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

Deep-sea mining moves in stages — exploration first, and only later, if at all, a commercial harvesting decision. That staged, still-open process is your opportunity: at every stage the precautionary principle applies, the marine park's governance engages, and the public and Parliament can shape the decision. The entry points are the Seabed Minerals Authority's process, the Marae Moana Council, the assessments, and the democratic and legal channels — all live, because no irreversible step has been taken.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the licences: who holds the exploration rights, and what precautionary commitments and assessments they carry. Follow the science: what is known — and, crucially, not known — about the deep-sea ecosystem's harm. Follow the ocean economy: what the tuna and the reefs are worth against the mining's promise. The leverage lies in the precautionary principle, the marine park's governance, the uncertain science, and the ocean economy.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The Cook Islands have real watchers: the Seabed Minerals Authority and its own precautionary commitments, the Marae Moana Council and its technical advisory group, Parliament, the courts, a free press, the traditional leaders, and the world's marine scientists. These are the institutions a case is built to engage — and, where they lean too far toward the mining, to hold to precaution and the park's purpose.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Opposition here is genuinely possible — indeed the decision is still open, which is the strongest position in this whole guide. The single most decisive move is **applying the precautionary principle to a barely-known deep sea**, because the government itself professes it, and because where harm is uncertain and potentially irreversible, the burden falls on proving safety. The marine park's governance is the distinctive framework; the tuna and ocean economy the strongest stake; the democracy's channels genuinely open. What the tools deliver is a decision shaped in the open — the precautionary principle applied, the park strengthened, the deep sea protected until understood — rather than a harm reversed. The odds, at a decision still open and met fairly, are real.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the irreversible damage to a barely-known deep-sea ecosystem, the risk to the tuna and ocean economy. **What is uncertain?** — the science, which cannot yet measure the harm, and to which the precautionary principle applies. **Which framework governs it?** — the marine park, the Seabed Minerals Authority, the precautionary commitments. **Which stage is it at?** — exploration, still open, years from any harvesting. **Who is the coalition?** — the traditional leaders, the fishers, the community, the scientists. Pick the entry where the precautionary principle and the marine park bite hardest, at a decision still open.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the uncertainty** — what is known and, crucially, not known about the deep-sea ecosystem, and the risk of irreversible harm. **Layer two: the principle and the framework** — the precautionary principle the government professes, the marine park's purpose and governance, the ocean economy at stake. **Layer three: the channel and the fairness** — which stage of the process to engage, which democratic or legal avenue to use, and an honest reckoning with the government's good-faith case for development, so the case answers it with a better path. A case built on the uncertain science, the precautionary principle, and the marine park's purpose is one a working democracy takes seriously at a decision still open.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **science record**: what is known and unknown about the deep-sea ecosystem, the risk of irreversible harm, the world's marine science. Gather the **framework record**: the precautionary principle in the government's own commitments, the Marae Moana purpose and spatial plan, the Seabed Minerals Authority's process. Gather the **economy record**: the tuna fishery, the ocean and tourism economy, weighed against the mining's promise. Gather the **coalition record**: the traditional leaders, the fishers, the community, the scientists, the press. The Cook Islands' openness makes most of this genuinely obtainable.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

The Cook Islands' strength is a working democracy with traditions and community intact. Build a coalition of the **traditional leaders (the Ariki and the community authority)**, the **fishers and ocean-economy communities**, the **civil society and environmental voices**, the **scientists** who hold the uncertainty, and the **free press**. Because the government's case for development is made in good faith, the strongest

coalition meets it fairly — showing how precaution and a protected ocean serve the nation's own future better than a rush into a barely-known deep sea. Build it around the ocean that is the Cook Islands' identity and economy.

STEP 4: PRECAUTION, THE MARINE PARK & DEMOCRACY — SHAPING THE DECISION

Set expectations honestly: here the levers are real and the decision still open, in a working democracy, though the government's case is fair and the science cuts both ways.

The Precautionary Principle

The distinctive lever is the **precautionary principle**: a deep-sea mining over an ecosystem so little understood its harm cannot be measured can be held to the precaution the government itself professes. Where harm is uncertain and potentially irreversible, the burden is to prove safety, not to assume it — and that principle, applied at a decision still open, is the strongest ground.

The Marine Park and Its Governance

The **Marae Moana marine park** — the world's largest — and its **Council, technical advisory group, and marine spatial plan** are the ocean's own governance, whose purpose can be strengthened and held against the mining. A mixed-use park can have its protections tightened, and its purpose invoked, through this governance.

The Democracy, the Economy, and the Science

Parliament, the courts, the free press, and civil society carry genuine avenues, and the **tuna and ocean economy** and the **world's science** are the stake and the evidence. Pursued together — the precautionary principle, the marine park, and the democracy — these levers shape the decision in the open, meeting the government's good-faith case with a better path.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the Seabed Minerals Authority**: here is the precautionary principle you profess, applied to a harm that cannot yet be measured. **For the Marae Moana Council**: here is the park's purpose, and the mining that tests it. **For Parliament and the public**: here is a frontier decision still open, and the case for precaution over a rush. **For the fishers and the economy**: here is the tuna and ocean wealth at risk. **For the government's development case**: here is a fair meeting of it — precaution and a better path, not a dismissal. **The golden rule**: apply the precautionary principle, strengthen the park, ground the case in the science and the ocean economy, and meet the good-faith development argument fairly — winning the decision rather than dismissing the other side.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In a working democracy with a free press, media matters. Frame the story around **a frontier decision, still open, and a barely-known deep sea**: not development against nature, but precaution over a rush into an ocean we do not yet understand. Carry it through the national press, the Pacific and international outlets, and the community's networks. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the science and the precautionary principle; meet the government's good-faith case fairly rather than caricaturing it; and let the

uncertainty, the marine park, and the ocean economy carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in precaution and the science, and fair to the good-faith development case.

8A — To the Seabed Minerals Authority: invoke the precautionary principle it professes, applied to a harm that cannot yet be measured, and ask for precaution at every stage.

8B — To the Marae Moana Council: connect the mining to the park's purpose and ask for its protections to be strengthened.

8C — To a member of Parliament: summarise the frontier decision and the case for precaution, and ask for scrutiny.

8D — To a marine scientist: request the evidence on the deep-sea ecosystem's uncertainty and harm.

8E — To the traditional leaders: set out the ocean stake and invite the community's authority.

8F — To the fishers and ocean-economy community: document the tuna and ocean wealth at risk, and invite the coalition.

8G — To the government (meeting its case): acknowledge the development argument and offer precaution and a better path.

8H — To the press: offer the documented precaution-and-uncertainty case and ask for coverage.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble what is known and unknown about the deep-sea harm and the precautionary principle in the government's commitments; write the one-page precaution case; reach the Marae Moana Council and the traditional leaders. **The fastest-moving levers:** the precautionary principle, the marine park's governance, and the democratic and press channels. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the traditional leaders, the fishers, and the scientists first; in so close a nation they mobilise quickly. Throughout, ground everything in precaution and meet the development case fairly.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Even in a working democracy the field can tilt: a government advocating the mining for the revenue, a mixed-use park whose protections can be bypassed, a science spun as more settled than it is. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot reach — the precautionary principle the government itself professes, the marine park's own governance, the courts, the free press, the traditional authority, the world's science. The decision is still open, which is the strongest position of all. Accept, honestly, that the government's case is fair and must be met fairly, not dismissed.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — a licence steered to insiders, a precautionary commitment quietly abandoned, science suppressed. Where capture appears, respond through the open channels the Cook Islands genuinely provide: the courts, the marine park's governance, Parliament, the free press, the

traditional authority, and the world's scientists. **On safety:** the Cook Islands are a safe, rule-of-law democracy; the risks here are political and reputational, not physical, so the work is open, lawful, and public — but always accurate, and fair to the good-faith case for development.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, at a decision still open. The documented uncertainty feeds the precautionary case, the marine-park governance, and the democratic and legal avenues at once; the traditional and community coalition organises alongside; the media carries the precaution-and-frontier frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the science and the precautionary principle, and engage the marine-park governance; **months two onward**, press the precautionary principle, strengthen the park, and use Parliament, the courts, and the press, meeting the development case fairly; **through the staged process**, shape each decision as it comes. The core discipline: grounded in precaution and the science, framework-driven, and fair to the good-faith case.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Cook Islands are among the most hopeful grounds in this guide, because the decision is still open and the democracy genuinely works. This guide has been honest that the mining is at exploration, years from any commercial decision — a moment to shape, not a harm to reverse; that the government's case for development and clean-energy minerals is made in good faith and must be met fairly; that the science is genuinely uncertain and cuts both ways; that the marine park is mixed-use; and that the small economy seeks the revenue. But those honest truths do not weaken the effort — they define its shape. A community that applies the precautionary principle the government itself professes to a barely-known deep sea, strengthens the Marae Moana marine park's purpose, grounds its case in the tuna, the ocean economy, and the world's science, uses the genuine channels of a working democracy, and meets the development argument fairly can genuinely shape this frontier decision, and protect a barely-known ocean until it is understood. The odds here, at a decision still open, are real, and the tools are strong.